

# Foreign Policymaking (EA)

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Political Science — Master Notes · by Jakob V. Stangel

**Required reading:** Ashbee, E. & Hurst, S. (2020), "The Trump foreign policy record and the concept of transformational change," *Global Affairs* 6(1): 5–19 · Putnam, R. (1988), "Diplomacy and Domestic Politics: The Logic of Two-Level Games," *International Organization* 42(3): 427–460 (to p.435). · Lecturer: Eddie Ashbee. (Putnam is CBS-library-only, not in the folder — the two-level-game section below is built from the deck + the standard framework; the win-set detail is the assigned part.)

**Theme of the lecture.** The IR theory lectures (I–IV) work mostly at the **international / state level** and treat what goes on *inside* a state as a "**black box**." This session **opens the box**: foreign policy is shaped by **domestic** as well as international variables, and the two **interact** — theorised through **neoclassical realism**, **Foreign Policy Analysis (FPA)**, and Putnam's "**two-level game**." The running case study is **US foreign policy since January 2017** — Trump and "Trumpism."

★ **The heart of the lecture:** foreign policy is **not** just a state responding to the international system — it is the **product of domestic politics interacting with international pressures**. IR's grand theories black-box the domestic; **FPA / neoclassical realism** open it, showing how **individuals, ideas, bureaucracies, interest groups and public opinion** shape policy. Putnam's **two-level game** models the interaction: a leader bargains **internationally (Level I)** and must get the deal **ratified at home (Level II)** at the same time. The **Trump** case tests whether a foreign-policy shift is "**transformational**" — a lasting change in **paradigm, interests, institutions and logics**.

**The red thread.** For any foreign-policy episode ask: *which domestic variables are in play, how do they interact with the international situation — and is the change **transformational** or just a passing shift?*

## Key concepts / "modes" to use

- The "**black box**" — why grand IR theory sidelines domestic politics.
  - **Foreign Policy Analysis (FPA) / neoclassical realism** — systemic pressures **filtered through** domestic intervening variables.
  - **Domestic variables** — individuals · ideas/ideologies · bureaucratic cultures · interest groups & constituencies · public opinion (+ **salience**).
  - **Transformational change** (Ashbee & Hurst) — a lasting shift in **paradigm · interests · institutions · logics**.
  - **Embeddedness** — ideas rooted in supportive **interests + institutions** (weak embeddedness → only "proto-transformational").
  - **Two-level game** (Putnam) — Level I (international bargaining) + Level II (domestic ratification); **win-sets**; the **Schelling conjecture**.
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## Opening the "black box" — why Foreign Policy Analysis? (deck)

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**Core:** the main IR theories are **international- or state-level** — they largely **relegate or disregard** domestic processes, treating the state as a **"black box"** that responds to the system.

- **Structural realism (Waltz):** international relations are **anarchic**, trust is limited, so **any** state (autocracy or democracy) must **prioritise its own security & survival** and will act if it has the **capacities**. (*Domestic type barely matters.*)
- **Liberal internationalism (Ikenberry):** looks a little more inside — it cares about the **character of political systems** (democracies tend to avoid offensive wars — answerable to the public, tied by trade **interdependence**, cooperating through **IOs**; the tongue-in-cheek "**Golden Arches** theory" — no two countries with McDonald's fight). But it still doesn't examine **internal processes** closely.
- **Foreign Policy Analysis (FPA) & neoclassical realism** open the box: foreign policy = the **interaction of international structure and domestic processes** — not one or the other.

### | Neoclassical realism — the bridge

**Core:** **neoclassical realism** keeps realism's **systemic** starting point (relative power, anarchy) but says those pressures are **filtered through domestic "intervening variables"** — leaders' perceptions, state–society relations, institutions — before they become policy. (*This is the neoclassical row of the realism family: "structure pushes, but domestic politics filters the push."*) → so **the same international pressure produces different policies** in different states, depending on the domestic filter. This is the theoretical warrant for spending the rest of the lecture on **domestic variables**.

## ★ Domestic variables that shape foreign policy (deck)

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**Core:** five families of domestic variable — each a lens, none sufficient alone.

| Variable                                         | What it captures                                                                                                                                                  | Watch-outs / examples                                                                                                                                 |
|--------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Individuals / core actors</b>                 | the " <b>great man theory of history</b> " (Carlyle: " <i>the history of the world is but the biography of great men</i> ") — leaders' beliefs, style, psychology | <b>Trump</b> (impulse control, short attention span). <i>But</i> focusing on individuals <b>neglects structural forces</b> (see below)                |
| <b>Ideas &amp; ideologies</b> ("belief systems") | the <b>paradigm</b> guiding policy — what problems/goals/instruments seem legitimate                                                                              | Was Trump-I "standard Republican fare" ( <b>Reagan's "peace through strength"</b> ) or a genuine break? ( <i>the debate the reading settles</i> )     |
| <b>Bureaucratic cultures &amp; sub-cultures</b>  | agencies' standing operating cultures; <b>coalitions &amp; factions</b> inside the executive                                                                      | State Dept vs Defense vs intelligence — "trade hawks" vs finance factions under Trump                                                                 |
| <b>Interest groups &amp; constituencies</b>      | <b>lobbying, campaigning, campaign contributions, the "revolving door"</b> — and geographic <b>constituencies</b> (e.g. rust-belt states)                         | note <b>instrumental power</b> (direct lobbying) vs <b>structural power</b> (business's leverage over investment/jobs)                                |
| <b>Public opinion</b>                            | mass attitudes constraining leaders (e.g. <b>Vietnam</b> disengagement blamed on unpopularity)                                                                    | ★ <b>salience</b> : except in <b>acute crisis or heavy losses</b> , public engagement with foreign policy is usually <b>LOW</b> (Durant & Diehl 1989) |

- **The structural counterweight (deck)**: an individual-only focus **underestimates context**. Trump's mercurial style was *enabled* by the **relative weakness of checks & balances** in the foreign-policy arena — plus deeper trends: **party polarisation, party homogenisation**, and a **populist shift**. (Cf. *Truman (1945–53) leading the US into international engagement — a mix of individual commitment + shifts in economic elites + strategic pressure from the USSR: several variables at once.*)

## ★ Case study — US foreign policy since 2017 (Ashbee & Hurst 2020)

### ▮ The paradigm Trump inherited

**Core:** to judge whether Trump is a *break*, you must know what he broke *from*. US foreign policy ran on **Liberal Internationalism (LI)** — itself the product of the **1940s transformation** — which then fragmented.

- **Liberal Internationalism (LI)** — after WWII the US committed to **open-ended international engagement + global leadership**, building the **UN, IMF, World Bank, GATT, NATO** and a domestic **national-security state** (National Security Act 1947 → DoD, Joint Chiefs, NSC, CIA). (*This is the reading's model of a completed transformation — see below.*)
- **Fragmentation from the 1970s**: LI split. Some (mainly **Democrats**) rejected the **use of force**; another grouping (mainly **Republicans**) rejected LI's **cooperative** side → **militant / conservative internationalism = primacism** (US primacy, "hard" power used **unilaterally** or in **coalitions of the willing**, sidelining the UN/multilateralism) **but** keeping a **moral purpose** — faith in **democracy &**

**freedom** (Bush's Iraq war, democracy promotion, nation-building, regime change) and trade liberalisation. This paradigm **weakened from ~2006**.

- **2016 — MAGA**: a populist reaction to "**elite projects**" and perceived **US decline**, addressing both domestic and foreign policy.

## ■ **Trump's first term (2017–21) — the populist-nationalist break**

**Core**: Trump = **primacism + economic nationalism + "principled realism"** — i.e. conservative internationalism **minus the moral purpose**. The reading distils a **populist-nationalist paradigm** of **five propositions**:

1. **The nation is core** — defined by **ethnicity/culture**, not ideals/principles (Bannon: "a nation with a culture — and a reason for being").
  2. **Zero-sum competition** — nations are locked in a **struggle for hegemony**; limited scope for cooperation (the 2017 National Security Strategy used "competition" **18 times**); the US has been "losing."
  3. **Anti-"globalism"** — the nation & its people have suffered from **globalism** and global elites ("the party of Davos").
  4. **Trade subordinated to the nation** — markets should serve national purposes; hostility to **NAFTA/TPP**; prefer **bilateral ("one-on-one") deals** where US preponderance wins; reject **multilateral** trade liberalisation.
  5. **Moral vision abandoned** — no more Reagan's "shining city" or Bush's freedom agenda; **rejects regime change / democracy promotion** ("we are not here to lecture").
- **In practice**: challenging **China**; **transactionalism**; negotiations with **Russia & North Korea**; **unilateralism**; **burden-sharing** demands on allies; doubts about **collective security (NATO)**; **protectionism**.

## ■ ★ **Was it *transformational*? — the Ashbee & Hurst framework**

**Core**: the paper's real contribution is a **precise definition of transformational change** (drawing on **Polanyi**, historical institutionalism, Skowronek). Transformational change = a **lasting** shift across **four** linked elements — not just dramatic-but-passing change.

| Element             | What must shift                                                                                | LI (1940s) — the model                                                   | Trump (2017+) — the "first cut"                                                                                                                                          |
|---------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Paradigm</b>     | the framework of ideas/goals/instruments (Hall) — until new ideas become <b>"common sense"</b> | open-ended engagement & liberal world order                              | populist-nationalist paradigm (anti-globalism, bilateralism, no moral purpose) — <b>but only "common sense" to the base</b>                                              |
| <b>Interests</b>    | new interests grip power; <b>new coalitions</b> (Skowronek)                                    | New-Deal coalition + "Wall Street"<br>Republicans sideline isolationists | FP "establishment" & peak business <b>sidelined</b> ; GOP base shifts to <b>non-college white workers</b>                                                                |
| <b>Institutions</b> | formal & informal institutional <b>re-ordering</b>                                             | UN/IMF/NATO + the national-security state                                | withdrawals ( <b>Paris, TPP, UNESCO, UN HR Council</b> ), undermining the <b>WTO</b> , gutting the <b>State Dept/IC</b> — <i>but</i> core alliances <b>remain intact</b> |
| <b>Logics</b>       | new <b>chains of events</b> /incentives that endure (path dependence)                          | enduring collective-security commitments                                 | weakened trans-Atlanticism; allies edge toward <b>self-reliance</b> ; TPP revived <b>without</b> the US                                                                  |

- ★ **The verdict:** applying the framework gives a **mixed picture** — the **beginnings of transformational change**, but **"incipient, partial and variegated."** The **ideational** shift is the most dramatic; institutional/interest shifts are real but **incomplete**; logics are hardest to read this early.

## ★ Embeddedness — why "proto-transformational"

**Core:** ideas only become a *lasting* transformation when they are **embedded** — i.e. **rooted in supportive interests and institutions** (so they outlive the leader). Trump's first-term primacism was **pursued inconsistently and weakly embedded** (he **marginalised** the national-security bureaucracy but did **not** rebuild it into a self-sustaining machine for the new paradigm) → only **"proto-transformational."**

- Two reasons it may not stick (reading):** (1) **populism is a "thin" ideology** (Mudde) — a **crust** on top of other ideologies, so the administration could be pulled **back** toward conservative/militant internationalism; (2) the US remains **locked into** its key post-war security institutions.

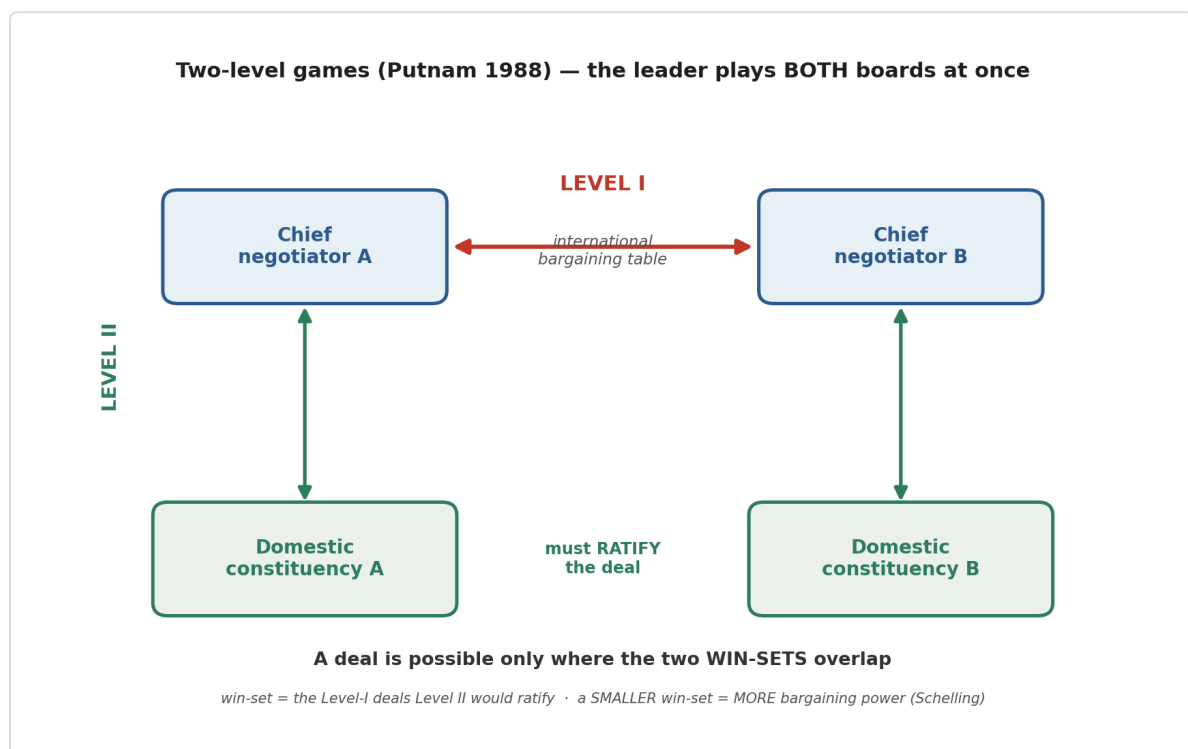
## Second term (2025+) & the Democrats (*deck*)

- Trump II / the GOP:** **no single guiding ideology** — pulled between rival **ideational clusters**. But some **constants** ("floating ideas") cut across the divisions: **support for Israel** (note the role of **religious conservatism** in the party), **disdain for Europe** + support for "patriotic" forces; **2026** sees growing divisions (e.g. **Iran**).
- Democrats:** **no clear foreign-policy orientation**; Biden's **"alliance of democracies"** gained limited traction; continued **opposition to China** + **support for Ukraine**; increasingly **divided over Israel/Palestine (Gaza)** (DNC vs DSA); 2028 wide open.

## ★ How do domestic & international variables interact? — the two-level game (Putnam 1988)

**Core:** domestic and international variables clearly interact — but *on what terms?* (avoid analytical "ad-hocery"). Putnam's answer: an international negotiation is a **single game played simultaneously at two interconnected levels**.

- **Level I** = bargaining between the negotiators at the international table.
- **Level II** = separate discussions inside each country about whether to **ratify** what the negotiator brings home.
- The leader sits at **both boards at once**: a deal must be **struck internationally** *and* **ratifiable domestically**.



**How to read it.** The key concept is the win-set = *the set of all Level-I deals that would win ratification at Level II*. Two consequences:

- A deal is possible only where the two win-sets **overlap** — bigger win-sets make agreement **more likely** (but risk a deal your public dislikes).
- ★ **The Schelling conjecture (the counter-intuitive bit):** a smaller win-set can give a negotiator **more bargaining power** — "I'd love to accept, but my parliament will never ratify that" forces the other side to move. Being **tied down at home** is a **bargaining asset** abroad.
- **Defection:** a deal can fail through **voluntary** defection (a rational leader reneges) or **involuntary** defection (the leader *can't deliver* because ratification fails at home). → *domestic and international politics are entangled, not separate*.

## | Or does the balance *vary*? (deck)

**Core:** an alternative to "it's always a two-level game" is that the **weight** of domestic vs international variables **varies systematically** — by:

- **Time-period** — domestic variables matter **less in acute crisis** (power centralises, the public rallies).
  - **State size** — **small states** may have **fewer foreign-policy options** (more constrained by the system).
  - **Regime type** — **liberal democracies** are arguably **more exposed to domestic pressures** than illiberal/authoritarian states.
  - **Policy arena** — some issues draw **much more domestic engagement** — most notably **trade**.
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## Cases & examples

- **The 1940s Liberal-Internationalism transformation.** Paradigm (global leadership) + interests (New-Deal/Wall-Street coalition) + institutions (UN/IMF/NATO + national-security state) + enduring logics. → *Illustrates: a **completed** transformational change — the model Trump is measured against.*
- **Trump-era US foreign policy (2017+).** Populist-nationalist paradigm, sidelined establishment, withdrawals from agreements, gutted State Dept — but intact alliances. → *Illustrates: "**incipient, partial and variegated**" transformation; **weak embeddedness** → proto-transformational.*
- **Vietnam disengagement.** Blamed on rising unpopularity — but note **salience** (opinion bites mainly under heavy losses). → *Illustrates: **public opinion** as a domestic variable, and its limits.*
- **Truman & international engagement (1945–53).** Individual commitment + elite shifts + USSR pressure. → *Illustrates: foreign policy as **several domestic + international variables interacting.***

## Key terms

| Term                             | Meaning                                                                                                         |
|----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| "Black box"                      | Grand IR theory treats the state's internal politics as unopened — inputs (system) → outputs (policy)           |
| Foreign Policy Analysis (FPA)    | The study of foreign policy as a product of domestic processes + international structure                        |
| Neoclassical realism             | Systemic pressures <b>filtered through</b> domestic intervening variables (leaders, institutions)               |
| Salience                         | How much the public actually attends to an issue (usually <b>low</b> for foreign policy)                        |
| Instrumental vs structural power | Direct lobbying vs business's leverage from control over investment/jobs                                        |
| Transformational change          | Lasting shift in <b>paradigm · interests · institutions · logics</b> (Ashbee & Hurst / Polanyi)                 |
| Embeddedness                     | Ideas rooted in supportive <b>interests + institutions</b> → they endure beyond the leader                      |
| Primacism                        | US <b>primacy</b> /preponderance as the organising aim of foreign policy                                        |
| Two-level game (Putnam)          | A negotiation played simultaneously at <b>Level I</b> (international) + <b>Level II</b> (domestic ratification) |
| Win-set                          | The set of Level-I deals that would be <b>ratified</b> at Level II; deals need <b>overlapping</b> win-sets      |
| Schelling conjecture             | A <b>smaller</b> win-set (tied hands at home) can mean <b>more</b> bargaining power abroad                      |

## Exam pointers

- Explain the **"black box"** critique and how **neoclassical realism / FPA** open it (systemic pressure **filtered through** domestic variables).
- List and apply the **five domestic variables** — and the **salience** caveat on public opinion.
- Define **transformational change** by its **four elements** (paradigm/interests/institutions/logics) and run it on **Trump** — verdict: **"incipient, partial and variegated"**; explain **embeddedness** and why Trump-I was only **proto-transformational**.
- Set out the **two-level game** (Level I/II, win-sets, the **Schelling conjecture**, voluntary vs involuntary defection).
- Give the **four ways the domestic–international balance may vary** (time/crisis, state size, regime type, policy arena — esp. **trade**).

**Bridge.** This lecture is the **hinge** between IR theory (I–IV) and real foreign-policy **practice**: the grand theories set the *international* stage, but **who a state actually is at home** — its leaders, ideas, bureaucracies, interests and publics — decides how it plays. The **two-level game** is the model of that interaction; **transformational change** is the yardstick for whether a shift will last.

## ★ Fun facts & memorable details (Foreign Policymaking)

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Sticky bits from the foreign-policymaking lecture.

- The "**Golden Arches**" **theory of peace**: no two countries that both have **McDonald's** had ever fought a war (a jokey stand-in for the liberal claim that **trade interdependence** deters war).
  - "**The history of the world is but the biography of great men**" (Carlyle, 1840) — the **great-man theory** the lecture uses to *set up* why leaders alone aren't enough.
  - **Tied hands are a bargaining chip**: Putnam/Schelling's counter-intuitive point — "*my parliament will never ratify that*" can win you a **better** deal. Weakness at home = strength abroad.
  - The **2017 US National Security Strategy** used the word "**competition**" **18 times** — the reading's neat evidence of the zero-sum, nationalist paradigm shift.
  - A "**hostile takeover**": a departing senior diplomat described Trump's first-year State Department — "*you decapitate the leadership, you compartmentalize the power centers, you engender fear and suspicion.*"
  - **Populism** is a "**thin**" ideology (Mudde) — a **crust** on top of other ideologies, which is why Ashbee & Hurst call Trump-I only "**proto-transformational**."
  - **Japan revived the TPP *without* the US** after Trump pulled out — a real "changed logic": the world starts building around, not through, Washington.
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## PART III · THE EUROPEAN UNION AS A POLITICAL SYSTEM